

This is day three of Andy and Allison's trip to London in August 2026. So, the previous two days had involved walking considerable distances. quite unexpected, maybe not particularly extreme, but nevertheless both our legs were now somewhat tired. Um we had felt particularly weary at the end of the second day. So we woke up day three thinking perhaps we should take it a little bit easier. Having said that, the first thing we had uh arranged to do on day three was a tour, a guided tour of uh the the Westminster area as it pertains and relates to Winston Churchill as a build up to getting to the what's called the war rooms, which is a visitor attraction in White Hall where you can go and explore the underground rooms that were used by the Winston Churchill government and military command during the Second World War to basically control operations safely from the bombing of the German Luftfa. And so that so the morning's um arrangements were to meet the tour guide at the Bodicea statue at the at the beginning of Westminster Bridge where the guide would take us around the area and explain various bits of history and talk about Winston Churchill and his life. Before finishing at the war rooms where we would then be free to go in, get ourselves of uh an audio guide and just wander around the war rooms and the Churchill Museum, both of which are located in the uh underground under one of the huge buildings at Whitehall. So the first thing we did, we left, we got up as usual in our hotel, Crown Plaza, King's Cross, now becoming quite familiar to us. down in the lift, outside and took our usual walk now to King King's Cross tube station. We got the train down to uh Westminster. We surfaced and we were nicely on time, maybe a little bit early, but not not too early. And we were lacking breakfast and and and and coffee. So we found a cafe Nero, ordered ourselves a nice coffee and a pastry or something like that. Sat on a bench looking at the Thames on embankment and enjoyed our our kind of outdoor breakfast. It was very pleasant. We then walked back up to the Bodicea statue where we met the tour guide, a woman called Marianne. And there were a group of us. There was um three other American ladies, two a woman, her daughter and the best friend of the mother, was the three Americans. And then there were another four, um I I think two were American and I think two were Eastern European somewhere. So we were a nice small party. Um and we started off with Marianne taking us along well talking to us about Bodicea. there was so much history that she explained, it was absolutely fantastic. She told us about Bodicea in the first century AD as a Britain, as a head of the uh I think it's the I I see I see I can't remember now. The the British Celtic tribe, I think it was the Ican. And how she fought the Romans um who wanted to basically take her land when her husband died. And how she nearly succeeded actually but didn't succeed in the end. But there she was defending London and she likened that to Churchill and the way Churchill had also protected London and England during the Second World War. Interesting fact number one was how the River Thames was very important for the German Luftfa because when the moon shone, they could pick out the reflected light on the River Thames and it gave them gave them a way of guiding their planes up into the center of London so they could bomb accurately the city and surrounding area. So, we walked up the embankment, she showed us some memorials to the uh Battle of Britain which and the Second World War, the fallen in the Second World War generally. uh which uh relatively recent monuments along the embankment sort of post 2000. Um had never noticed them before, amazingly, but interesting to see them. We crossed the road to uh one of the large whitehall buildings where she showed us the original Queen Anne the second steps. These were the steps that came out of the the palace that used to be on that side since gone, but the steps remain. and she explained how Queen Anne the second would descend those steps to the River Thames. Now the River Thames is far, it's something like 20 meters further away uh the other side of embankment. And it actually just shows how wide the Thames would have been in those

days. Um in actual fact, um you know, the embankment was built up and now those steps are just well inside, well, you know, well back from the river bank. So, she showed us a little bit more, we walked down past the Ministry of Defense, past the original building that was there where the war office was in the first and second World Wars. And then onto the uh entrance to Horse Guards Parade, which I've never been to before. And we timed it perfectly because the horses were just coming out. They'd been away for a while, but they were just coming out again. And they ceremoniously came through the arch, came through the the entrances and stood proudly with the horse back while we as tourists looked on. It was quite a spectacle. We then walked further up towards Trafalgar Square where we looked at the original building, which was the where Churchill was head of the Admiralty, and where he had resided. All of this all of the history was connected with Churchill. And then we we walked back, we went through the archway into um Horse Guards Parade. She explained some of the buildings around there. And then we walked back, and then we spent quite a lot of time outside Banquet House or Banqueting House where she gave us a very interesting and quite well, very well explained history of the monarchy back from James the second, which I which was when banquet Banqueting House was uh originally built. And it was built it was designed by an architect called Inigo Jones. He's the first recognized English architect who had been to Italy and brought back some of the Italian um design uh architecture themes. Inside the ceilings are painted by Rubens. Um it's an incredibly historical uh building. She went on to explain how, I think it was James the second's third son, Charles the first, is it? Or Charles the second, I can't remember. Uh how he had succeeded James the second, but had been quite a controversial monarch because he had believed he he was ruling, he had the uh authority of of God to rule the country and effectively ignored the government. Eventually this came to a head when he from he he was in the north, he was in in the Midlands in Nottingham where he basically declared war on the on the um on the government and the British people as as head as the monarch. And that led to the English Civil War which raged for some time until and killed hundreds of thousands until eventually um he lost the the war, uh Oliver Cromwell and um the the um the government forces won the Civil War. Um and um and and that was the end of of of of Charles basically. Um so Oliver Cromwell ruled. Eventually his his his son took over from Oliver Cromwell, but his son didn't turn out to be suitable for that kind of role. And sometime later, um the monarch was restored. Uh and it was called the restoration of the monarchy. And there's a she explained how that time, um the new monarch spoke from Banqueting House and addressed and addressed an assembled uh group of people or the the population basically. Um you know, and then and then that that led on to future kings and queens of of England. And it was very interesting, very, very interesting. Uh we then kept going, we walked up to Westminster itself and we walked around the square. Now something quite amazing, at least amazing to me was that I have got a recollection or a memory of visiting London when I was I now realize I was nine years old. And I and I went with James, my my brother, who sadly later passed away when he was 13. But together we went into London. And we visited my uncle Chris, which is my mother's younger brother, youngest brother. And we visited Chris who lived in Fulham at the time with his, I think it was his girlfriend, later to become his wife, Angie. Um and Angie remains a close friend of my mom to this day. And um they Chris drove us around London and what as we were driving around Westminster, they were unveiling the statue of Churchill. I remember it very well. And I remember Chris saying, you know, and also my dad commenting later when I told him about it, how we would always remember being there on the very moment that the statue to Winston Churchill was unveiled. And there I was some whatever it is, it would have been 1973. So, some I've got to get this right now. I think it's uh

50 Let me get this right. Let me get this right. So, it would have been Some 50 two years later. or 53 years later. Um because it was unveiled in 1973, and I was born in 1964. Um there I was, um again, out stood right opposite or right next to the Winston Churchill statue being you know, having a less or having a tour of that person's history and looking at that same statue that I'd seen unveiled. I mentioned this to the tour guide, who was suitably impressed and confirmed that this was not just a recollection, but probably true because the dates tallied 1973, I would have visited in when I was around about nine years old. So that was a nice little moment. We looked at some of the other statues as well. And then we moved on to um we moved on to the war rooms. And then we said goodbye to Marianne and we thanked her for a very interesting tour. We also chatted a bit to some of the other people on the tour from some Americans from North Carolina who were loving the history of England. And um told me how fearful she was of driving in the country for some reason. She just told me that fact. And driving on the wrong side of the road with a gear stick was like her idea of a nightmare. But that's just a slightly irrelevant aside. So then we went in the war rooms. We wandered around. We looked at all the exhibits. It was fantastic. Um went into the museum, saw the map room which is basically it is claimed to be virtually exactly as it was left on the last day when the war was finally over and they shut the doors on the war room on the on those war rooms. The map room was left completely untouched until you know, even today it's just as it was left. So it was fascinating to look at it and think that is exactly what it was was in the late in the sort of mid-40s with the war years are ending in 45. So we came out of the war rooms, and we were somewhat having trying to take it easy. Once again the legs, certainly my legs. I think Allison was fairing a little better than I, but I was so weary of just constantly of just being on my feet for so long. So we decided to walk across to St. James's Park and take in the um rent a couple of deck chairs like the elderly couple that we have become and look at these I think it's the Serpentine. Um anyway, the lake on St. James's in St. James's Park. We were somewhat staggered to see uh Pelicans. Lots and lots of Pelicans just living completely um free, you know, if you like, not not not not captivate, not in uh not in captivity. Whatever the word is, not in capture. And um also we saw like various exotic bird life, Egyptian geese, there were some herons, there were some many different types of wild aquatic bird life. It was quite quite incredible to watch. So we sat in our deck chairs, read books until we decided we really ought to go and do something. So we decided we would do something very leisurely. So we went back down to the Thames, and we hired or we bought tickets for a um boat trip from Westminster Pier down to Greenwich via Tower Hill. And once again, we got on the boat um and we sat down out upside open deck. Now both Allison and I, and in fact our children Beth and Jack, none of us have sea legs or even river legs for that matter. So as I got on, I could feel the boat swaying. I started to panic a bit thinking, would I be okay? I'm glad to say that it all worked out well and I didn't succumb to any feelings of sickness, but there was a moment when I was slightly worried. And off we went. And once again, after all the history of Churchill and the war, we got another fascinating history talk of the banks of the Thames. The tour guide or the it was the crew members of the boat provided the the guide, but they were extremely funny as well as informative telling us all about sort of his the history of the buildings that flanked the banks of the Thames. And interesting snippets like warf, W H A R F E or W H A R F standing for warehouse at riverfront. I already knew that, but it was um a nice reminder. And also talking about the pubs that, you know, banked the Thames, some of which have go back centuries, I've even to the sort of 16th century, the prospect of Whitby, I remember because I've been to that pub in my youth when we lived in London. Um, the sort of history of the bridges and uh it was really really fascinating. We got to Greenwich. We didn't really

have much time in Greenwich. We just sat in a pub again becoming a bit of a theme, had a drink and um we decided that evening we'd go and watch a film at the cinema. Like we had nothing planned, but like the previous nights we'd been to see um the um witness for the prosecution, followed by six, the musical, we had nothing planned for that night. So we looked on the Vue cinema web pages and just picked a film called Dog Star. Now Dog Star is directed by Ridley Scott. Uh and it's about a post-apocalyptic kind of world and it just looked like it would probably be quite good and we just thought we'll take a chance and go. So we got back on the ferry or on the boat from Greenwich. We went back up to Westminster. And we worked our way up to Piccadilly. We got to Piccadilly Circus. We we surface from the tube right on right at Piccadilly Circus where you always have to say when you arrive it's the one time you can say with complete accuracy it's like Piccadilly Circus around here, which is what you say when it's very busy no matter where you are. But in Piccadilly Circus it's just highly applicable. So we both said that. Um, we had just a few minutes, so we just wandered around a little bit, settled ourselves into the cinema and watched one of the most awful films either of us have ever seen. It was so bad it was actually quite funny. The dialogue was awful. The actual cinematography was quite good. There were some pretty nice scenes but the whole thing was just awful, just just pure terrible dialogue, just pointless act well, the acting was okay, but the whole thing was just completely pointless and incredibly difficult to believe. Never mind. We kind of found it funny just how dreadful it was. Um anyway, that was that. We then came out of the cinema and um we had a we were hungry by that point. So we popped into a nearby pizza hut. Hadn't been in a pizza hut for many, many years and was somewhat delighted to find it's barely changed. You know, the sort of all you can eat salad, um you know, the sort of pizzas pretty much as I remember them. Lots of chili flakes to make them a bit more a bit more appetizing. Uh of course, the obligatory few fries. Um and we ate that up. And then we we kind of came out of Piccadilly, came out of the pizza hut, back onto the Piccadilly tube station, made our way up to King Cross King's Cross. And then the now very familiar walk around to our Crown Plaza hotel at King's Cross where we got into our room, both tired and uh look reflecting on a day of much history and very, very enjoyable.